



J. Safran Sarasin Cross-Asset Weekly

10 April 2026

The twisted path towards an exit

The ceasefire with Iran has provided President Trump with a welcome off-ramp. Many details of the agreement remain unclear or even disputed. What is known so far suggests that it is more of a framework for negotiations than a fully defined agreement. The situation remains fragile and improvised, and far from a true resolution. Therefore, the set of potential outcomes remains wide, with probabilities quite evenly distributed. Yet we believe that some form of agreement, formal or tacit, is the most likely outcome. In such a setting, the oil price should settle at somewhat lower levels than today, but not fall to pre-war levels. While not an optimal outcome, it would limit the economic fallout compared to a prolonged conflict. We provide a Q&A on the war in Iran, focussing on key questions regarding geopolitical consequences, the macroeconomic impact and implications for financial markets.

Finally, we take a look at the Q1 reporting season in the US. Consensus expectations project another quarter with 13% EPS growth despite the war in Iran. Financials should benefit from higher rates, elevated volatility and strong M&A activity in Q1. Tech consensus earnings have been upgraded strongly into the season, but should be broadly met. One reason for concern is slowing hyperscaler earnings growth, which may eventually impact capex spending plans.

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War in Iran

Ceasefire: The implications

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Following the announcement of the ceasefire on Wednesday, we published an update to our scenario analysis. You can find the full text [here](#). We summarize the key takeaways in this short note. President Trump has secured a much-needed off-ramp in the form of a ceasefire. Iran says it will reopen the Strait of Hormuz while negotiations proceed over the next fortnight. What these talks will yield is unclear: the parties' demands remain far apart. We expect a deal to be signed in our base case, which would prevent a renewed flare-up of tensions. The oil price should settle at around USD80 to USD90/bbl by the end of the year, reducing the economic fallout compared to a prolonged conflict. We would expect bond markets to retain some expectations for rate hikes and stable to slightly lower long-term yields. The US dollar has room to fall further after its recent spike. Gold should climb back above USD5000/oz and equities should re-rate. While oil-sensitive sectors should lead the near-term rebound, tech, EM equities and US equities should lead over the medium term.

The ceasefire reduces the left-tail risk of an uncontrolled escalation

Iran says it will reopen the Strait of Hormuz while negotiations proceed over the next fortnight. What these talks will yield is unclear: the parties' demands remain far apart. Still, the US administration will probably be able to present any deal as a victory at home, even if, strategically, the US may achieve little or, quite likely, will end up in a worse place. Of course, much will depend on the final terms of the deal, if one is reached at all. Yet it seems likely that the regime in Tehran—hardened and resilient—will feel emboldened to continue its nuclear and ballistic programmes, even if it offers limited assurances at the table. Unless a substantial international naval presence remains in the Gulf for years, Iran is likely to retain de facto control of the Strait of Hormuz, and thus leverage over the world economy and the US. Even so, the ceasefire is welcome. It reduces the risk of escalation and of lasting damage to energy and other critical infrastructure, which would be highly damaging to the global economy and financial markets.

Exhibit 1: Updated scenario analysis

Scenario / probability	Assumptions	Economic Impact	Market Impact
Formal deal 40%	Details: Some agreement on nuclear and ballistic missile programmes Strait of Hormuz: Iran keeps de-facto control of strait, allows majority of the non-rerouted oil to go through	Oil price at \$80/bbl by year end Inflation: 0.2%-0.6%pts higher in AEs, Growth: 0.2-0.4%pts lower in AEs CBs: ECB and BoE hike 12 in 2026 & cut in 2H2027. Fed keeps rate unchanged this year, cut once in 2027	Fixed Income: Partial retracement from sharp rise in policy rate expectations, markets will retain some hiking expectations FX: USD to weaken, EURUSD towards 120, EURCHF at around 0.92 Gold: Climb back above \$5'000/oz in the near term Equities: S&P 500 to climb back to 6'900 quickly. End-year target of 7'400 remains in place. Preference for tech, EM and US equities
US walks away 30%	Details: No formal agreement can be reached, indeterminate ceasefire Strait of Hormuz: Iran keeps de-facto control, allows only some of the non-rerouted oil to go through	Oil price at \$90/bbl by year end Inflation: 0.3%-0.9%pts higher in AEs, Growth: 0.3-0.6%pts lower in AEs CBs: ECB and BoE hike 12 in 2026 & cut in 2H2027. Fed keeps rate unchanged this year, cut once in 2027	Fixed Income: Partial retracement from rise in policy rate expectations, markets will retain some hiking expectations FX: USD at around current levels, EURUSD and EURCHF unchanged Gold: Climb back towards \$5'000/oz in the near term Equities: S&P 2026 year-end target remains at 7'400
Prolonged escalation 20%	Details: Negative spiral of escalation, other gulf sates enter the war Strait of Hormuz: Remains closed & permanent damage to energy infrastructure	Oil price rises above \$150/bbl, at \$100/bbl by year end Inflation increases by >2%pts in AEs, second-round effects Growth: Global recession CBs: Early hikes are reversed quickly with deep cuts as we move into 2027	Fixed Income: Substantially lower yields, sharp widening in credit spreads FX: USD to rise, EURUSD below 115, EURCHF at around 0.90 Gold: High near-term volatility, but eventually higher Equities: Volatility spikes (VIX>40), 15% equity drawdown to (S&P<6'200)
Iranian regime collapses 10%	Details: Iran regime capitulates under military pressure Strait of Hormuz: Free passage fully restored	Oil price at \$65/bbl by year end Inflation: Somewhat higher Growth: limited economic impact CBs: Pre-war path	Fixed income: Retracement of rate expectations to pre-war levels, curve re-steepening FX: USD to weaken, EURUSD around 120, EURCHF above 0.92 Gold: Climb towards \$5'000/oz in the near term Equities: Volatility drops (VIX<20), 2026 end-year target remains in place (S&P: 7'400)

Source: Bank J. Safra Sarasin, 09.04.2026



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Q&A on the war in Iran

Macro and market considerations

The situation in Iran remains volatile. The two-week ceasefire—intended to create breathing room for diplomacy—is already under strain and the set of potential outcomes remains wide. In this Q&A, we focus on key questions regarding the potential resolution to the conflict. We delve into the geopolitical consequences, evaluate the macroeconomic impact and discuss implications for financial markets.

A. Geopolitics and macro

Will the ceasefire hold?

The ceasefire looks fragile. Israel insists Lebanon is not covered, even though the deal's broker, Pakistan's prime minister, Shehbaz Sharif, says otherwise. The arrangement also bears the hallmarks of expediency. The bottom line is that Donald Trump needed an off-ramp, judging by his remarks. He has described Iran's ten-point framework as "a workable basis" for talks, though much of it reads as maximalist and difficult to square with American interests. Key terms remain vague: what, for instance, counts as "free" passage? Tehran does not interpret this as toll-free, and Washington has offered little clarification. Unsurprisingly, only a trickle of ships has passed through the Strait of Hormuz over the past couple of days. Even so, the ceasefire is likely to endure—even if only partially respected—because neither side has much appetite for further escalation, in our view.

Why do we think that some form of deal is more likely than not?

Both parties' demands are maximalist, and, as such, irreconcilable. Still, both parties have an interest to see the oil go through the Strait of Hormuz. For President Trump, this means a lower oil price, which he needs if he wants to retain any chance of keeping at least one of the houses in the midterms. For Iran, the ability to levy transit fees would provide a quick source of revenue to rebuild its battered economy. So, in the end, pragmatism may trump principle. It is entirely possible, however, that no deal is reached before years and that the US administration shifts its focus on something else. Ships will go through the Strait of Hormuz, but it is Iran that would largely dictate the terms of passage. We have attached a 30% probability to this scenario.

What sort of deal might emerge?

Probably an unsatisfactory one. If Iran were to secure de facto control over the Strait, it would mark a strategic setback for America, which previously guaranteed freedom of navigation. Washington might tolerate such an outcome temporarily—perhaps to buy time until after the midterms—before seeking to reverse it later. Another option would involve an international naval presence to safeguard shipping, in exchange for sanctions relief. That would still hand Tehran a net gain: leverage over the Strait in return for economic concessions. American demands for limits on Iran's nuclear and missile programmes seem unlikely to be met, especially under a hard-line leadership.

When will traffic through the Strait return to normal?

Not soon—if ever. The immediate priority will be clearing fully laden tankers from the Gulf before empty vessels return. But shipping capacity is already stretched, with many vessels diverted elsewhere. Even after the ceasefire in Yemen between the US and the Houthis, Red Sea traffic remains far below pre-crisis levels. Insurance costs for transiting Hormuz will stay high until risks become clearer. Unlike the Red Sea, however, there are few viable alternative routes, limiting the scope for rerouting. Over time, Gulf states may invest more in pipelines to reduce dependence on maritime routes. For now, higher oil prices look entrenched.



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Who stands to win from the new situation?

China stands out. The crisis is likely to accelerate electrification and the broader energy transition, boosting demand for electric vehicles, batteries, solar panels and other technologies in which China dominates. Geopolitics may also shift in its favour. If NATO cohesion weakens, Europe may reassess its strategic autonomy—and, by extension, its relationship with China. Meanwhile, America's allies, especially in the Gulf and Asia, may begin to question the reliability of American security guarantees.

Will the world economy return to its pre-war state?

A: No. Oil prices are likely to settle in the \$80–90 range, reflecting tighter supply. That implies higher inflation and weaker growth. In advanced economies, inflation could end the year 0.2-0.9 percentage points above pre-war expectations, with growth 0.2-0.6 points lower. Central banks may keep policy tighter for longer, dampening credit creation. Supply disruptions, as seen during the pandemic, may also prove persistent. Repairing damaged energy infrastructure and restoring production could take months. In emerging markets (EM), the impact on growth should be somewhat larger. Many EM governments limit the pass-through of oil prices through energy subsidies, implying less inflationary impact but more fiscal burden.

B. Asset classes

Why have markets reacted the way they did despite the fragility of the ceasefire?

Because it signalled 'restraint'. Investors inferred that neither side seeks all-out conflict. For President Trump, keeping the Strait closed for even a fortnight would risk physical oil shortages in major economies, potentially pushing prices towards \$130 a barrel. Widespread damage to regional infrastructure would carry global consequences and dent America's standing. The Iranian regime, for its part, has shown it can disrupt the world economy—but prolonging the conflict would heighten the risk to its own survival as economic and physical damage mounts.

Markets expect central bank rate hikes. Why would they hike into a supply shock?

Preserving price stability is a key competence of any independent central bank. After the painful experience with the inflation surge in 2021/2022, central banks do not want to be caught off guard again. An unchecked rise in inflation expectations that leads to a change in people's behaviour and hence to more permanent inflation pressures is a major worry for central banks. Therefore, they are prepared to tighten financial conditions by raising policy rates, if need be, mindful that these measures are an additional headwind for an economy that may already be grappling with demand destruction.

What is the message for fixed income investors?

The immediate consequence is a rise in bond yields across the curve, i.e., lower bond prices, as the new likely trajectory of policy rates is incorporated along the yield curve. Higher yields imply higher expected total returns. Moreover, tighter financial conditions imply more headwinds for growth ahead and a higher likelihood of lower interest rates going forward. In short, the current repricing in expected central bank policy trajectories raises the attractiveness of fixed income investments.

Is the recent flattening of global yield curves an indication for slower growth ahead?

Precisely, the recent repricing of the trajectory for short-term rates implies less need for additional hikes over the medium term as growth is more negatively impacted. Term premiums for holding additional duration risk have dropped over the past few weeks, suggesting that markets are more comfortable with inflation risks. This is consistent with market-implied longer-term inflation expectations that are lower than at the start of the year, despite a sharp rise in short-term inflation expectations.

Does it still make sense to invest in credit?

Higher interest rates and potentially softer economic growth are usually not a good environment for corporate credit quality. Stress is building in some segments of credit markets, mainly in private credit. While corporate profitability remains generally strong and



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publicly traded credit markets have proved to be resilient, the environment is clearly becoming more challenging. We remain neutral on credit for now, given that carry is an important return contributor in 2026, although we attentively watch this space. But we stress that credit exposure should be balanced with a high-quality duration component.

Does the continued uncertainty suggest a further appreciation of the US dollar?

The dollar typically strengthens in an environment characterised by elevated (geopolitical) uncertainty. We think that the dollar has probably peaked in March and should weaken from here, unless we see a meaningful military re-escalation between Iran and the US. We believe this is less likely, as both sides have strong incentives to deescalate. A formal deal or the collapse of the Iranian regime would represent the most dollar-bearish outcomes, in our view, while a reescalation and prolongation of the military conflict would likely trigger a rebound of the dollar.

Should we expect a revival of the gold rally?

A US-Iran deal, under which Iran reopens the Strait of Hormuz for most of the traffic, should be a positive for gold, but the precious metal should similarly benefit in case President Trump decides to walk away without a deal. Along with the retracement of rate expectations from their March highs, which have allowed gold to rebound from its lows in recent days, both outcomes are set to have a longer-term negative effect on the global reach of the US, supporting structural demand for gold as an alternative reserve asset to the US dollar. By contrast, a resumption of military action with resurging energy prices would likely leave gold volatile in the near term, while the precious metal should recover once the market shifts its focus to the economic fallout.

Is the rebound in equity markets complete?

Equity markets have followed the oil price in lockstep, with US and global equities rising/falling by ~1.5% for every 10% drop/rise in the oil price. As we would expect oil prices to fall by no more than 20% from current levels (not below USD80/bbl), a potential rebound is limited to 3% (S&P 500 at 7000). The rebound would see oil-sensitive sectors, such as industrials, discretionary and materials, outperform.

How to position in equity markets beyond the conflict in the Middle East?

Once the rebound is complete, sector fundamentals should matter more for performance in our view. We think tech looks attractive in this regard. Earnings have risen and valuations have fallen across tech industries (semis, hardware, software) over recent months, leaving the sector as one of the most attractive propositions in the market right now. This should also provide support to EM equities and US equities in a regional equity allocation.



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US equities

Q1 preview: High expectations, solid fundamentals

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Q1 reporting is starting in earnest next week, with consensus expectations projecting another quarter with 13% EPS growth. Despite the war in Iran, earnings should come in reasonably strong. Financials should benefit from higher rates, elevated volatility and strong M&A activity in Q1. Energy earnings expectations have yet not caught up with the oil price and are set to surprise to the upside. Tech consensus earnings have been upgraded strongly into the season, but should be broadly met. One reason for concern is slowing hyperscaler earnings growth, which may eventually impact capex spending plans. This is certainly a key focal point for investors in Q1 earnings calls.

Q1 reporting starts next week with financials dominating the first days of the season

US Q1 reporting is starting in earnest next week before ramping up throughout April and seeing the largest number of reports in the last week of the month (Exhibit 1). Banks traditionally dominate the first days of the season. Goldman Sachs will be reporting on Monday, while Wells Fargo, Citigroup and JP Morgan will report on Tuesday and Bank of America on Wednesday.

S&P 500 EPS are set to grow by 13% yoy, which would be on par with Q4 2025

Financials are expected to deliver EPS growth of 17%, which would mark the strongest quarter since Q4 2024. Q1 consensus expectations in general are at the upper end of the range. If reported EPS growth for the entire S&P 500 were to meet consensus expectations of 13%, it would be one of the best quarters over recent years (Exhibit 2).

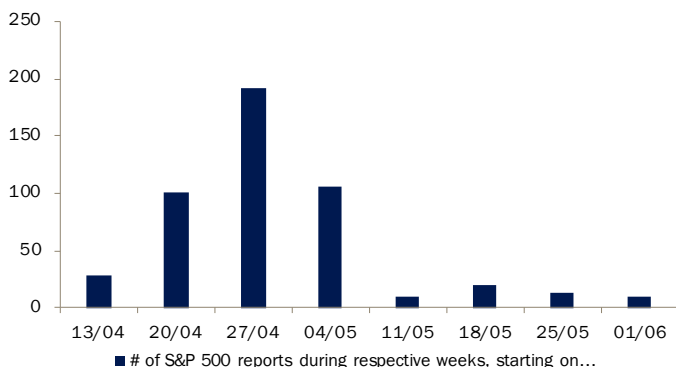
Top-down data and bottom-up data point to solid earnings delivery

While this looks like a high bar to meet, it is not unreasonable that EPS growth will come in at or above those levels. First, from a macro point-of-view, nothing points to an earnings-beat rate significantly below its long-term average of 70%. Secondly, bottom-up sector data also suggest solid support across industries.

Financials' earnings should be supported by solid macro data, higher yields, elevated volatility and strong M&A activity

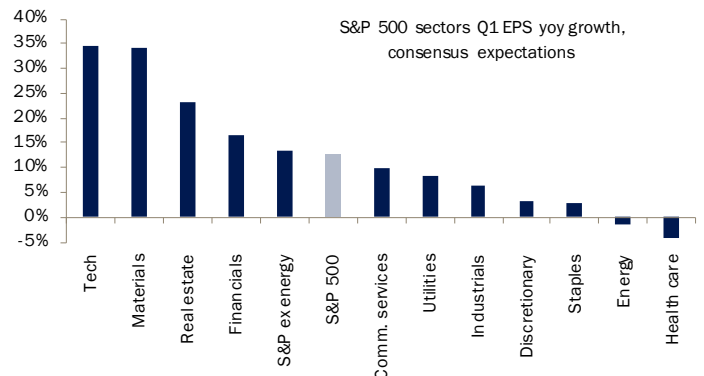
With regard to macro data, the rise in cyclical indicators, such as the ISM manufacturing and retail sales as well as solid labour market data indicate that the US cycle is fairly healthy and may even have strengthened in Q1. At the sector level, banks should be able to meet or beat consensus expectations. The rise in long-term bond yields in Q1, coupled with solid macro data, elevated market volatility (which boosts trading revenues) and rising M&A activity (driven by some large-scale transactions) bodes fairly well for the sector.

Exhibit 1: Most active week of the season at the end of April



Source: LSEG Datastream, Bank J. Safra Sarasin, 09.04.2026

Exhibit 2: Tech set to lead in terms of earnings growth



Source: LSEG Datastream, Bank J. Safra Sarasin, 09.04.2026



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Energy consensus earnings have not yet caught up with oil prices

Consensus expectations have also clearly trailed the recent rise in oil prices, which will likely deliver a significant bump to energy sector earnings in Q1 - in particular in the US, where supply shortages are less prevalent than in other regions (Exhibit 3). Consensus estimates for energy earnings typically trail oil and gas prices by around eight weeks, which means that they are not yet capturing the recent surge in response to the Iran war. The 2% decline, expected by consensus for energy EPS in Q1, will thus easily be beaten. The sector will very likely add to S&P 500 Q1 EPS growth instead of detracting from it.

Tech earnings expectations surged in Q1

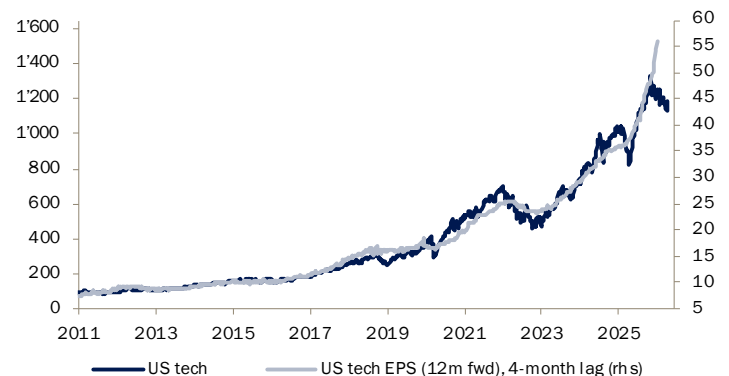
The sector which is set to see the highest EPS growth number is tech. Consensus expectations have been upgraded significantly over recent months, resulting in a 35% yoy growth rate projection for Q1. This would mark the highest quarterly earnings growth rate over recent years and even beat the 33% growth rate the sector posted in Q4 2025. Earnings upgrades for tech stand in contrast with performance (Exhibit 4). Over the past 15 years, there has never been a larger disconnect between tech earnings expectations and tech performance. This has led to a sharp de-rating of the sector and provides a sizeable buffer even if earnings were to disappoint at the margin.

Exhibit 3: Energy earnings yet have to catch up with oil & gas



Source: LSEG Datastream, Bank J. Safra Sarasin, 09.04.2026

Exhibit 4: Tech earnings have surged while the sector has fallen

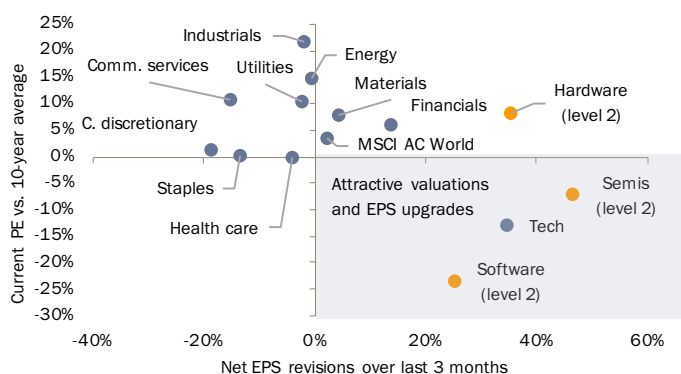


Source: LSEG Datastream, Bank J. Safra Sarasin, 09.04.2026

Tech upgrades have been broad-based, driven by semiconductor earnings

It should be noted that EPS upgrades have been broad-based across tech sub-sectors. Software, hardware and semiconductors have seen stronger EPS upgrades than any level 1 sector over the past three months (Exhibit 5). At the same time, tech is the only level 1 sector in the S&P 500 whose price-to-earnings-ratio (PE) is currently below its 10-year average. Software certainly continues to face AI-disruption risks and looks like the most challenged sub-sector in tech, but is already priced for a severe downside case (Exhibit 6).

Exhibit 5: Tech sub-sectors are ranking well on PE vs EPS plot



Source: LSEG Datastream, Bank J. Safra Sarasin, 09.04.2026

Exhibit 6: Software PE premium at lowest since 2009



Source: LSEG Datastream, Bank J. Safra Sarasin, 09.04.2026



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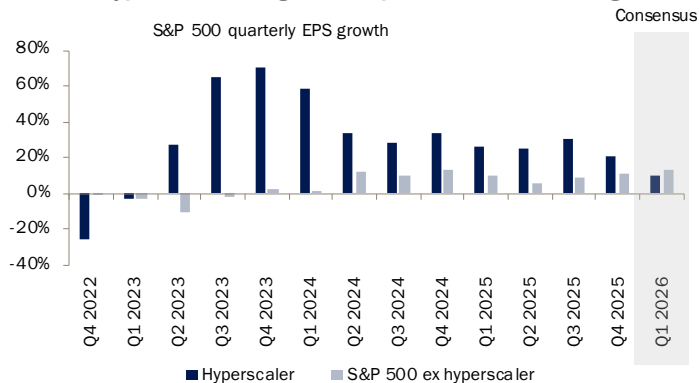
Semiconductors' earnings expectations have surged but early reporting from chipmakers suggests that AI demand is holding up in Q1

Semiconductor earnings expectations have surged, driven by Nvidia. As there has not yet been a slowdown in hyperscaler capex spending, the sector should be able to meet expectations. The continued strength in demand in the AI supply-chain is also reflected by Korean chipmaker Samsung's Q1 guidance this week, with the company indicating EPS to come in 50% above consensus expectations. Similar strength could also be observed in Taiwanese chipmaker TSMC's Q1 numbers, which comfortably beat consensus expectations.

Hyperscaler earnings growth expectations have fallen significantly, driven by Meta and Amazon

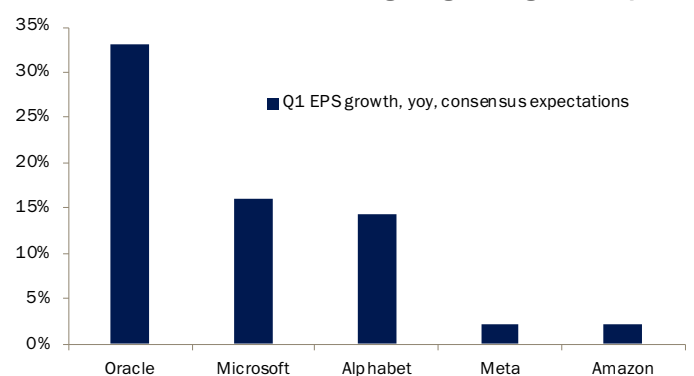
Meanwhile, hyperscalers themselves have lost some steam. For the first time since Q1 2023, EPS of the five large hyperscalers is set to grow at a lower rate than for the S&P 500 excluding those hyperscalers. Their combined EPS growth is set to slow to 10%, which would also be the lowest number since Q1 2023, while the rest of the market is set to accelerate to 13.5% (Exhibit 7). Why does this weakness among hyperscalers not show in tech earnings assumptions? Amazon and Meta are not part of the tech sector, but part of communication services and consumer discretionary, respectively. They are the laggards, with their EPS growth expectations in the low-single-digits (Exhibit 8).

Exhibit 7: Hyperscaler EPS growth expected below market growth



Source: LSEG Datastream, Bank J. Safra Sarasin, 09.04.2026

Exhibit 8: Meta and Amazon with single-digit EPS growth expected



Source: LSEG Datastream, Bank J. Safra Sarasin, 09.04.2026

AI capex guidance will be in focus

This is probably one of the largest red flags for the market right now. If hyperscalers' earnings deteriorate significantly over coming months and quarters, capex plans may be scaled back. This would likely have significant repercussions for the tech sector and the US cycle in general. We don't expect this to happen in the very near term but updates to their capex guidance will surely be something to watch in their respective reporting on 30 April (Meta) and 1 May (Amazon).



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Economic Calendar

Week of 13/04 – 17/04/2026

Country	Time	Item	Date	Unit	Consensus Forecast	Prev.
Monday, 13.04.2026						
US	16:00	Existing Home Sales MoM	Mar	mom	--	1.70%
Tuesday, 14.04.2026						
US	14:30	PPI Ex Food and Energy YoY	Mar	yoy	--	3.90%
Wednesday, 15.04.2026						
FR	08:45	CPI EU Harmonized MoM	Mar F	mom	--	1.10%
	08:45	CPI EU Harmonized YoY	Mar F	yoy	--	1.90%
US	13:00	MBA Mortgage Applications	Apr10	wow	--	-0.80%
	14:30	Empire Manufacturing	Apr	Index	--	-0.20
	16:00	NAHB Housing Market Index	Apr	Index	--	38.00
Thursday, 16.04.2026						
UK	08:00	Index of Services MoM	Feb	mom	--	0.00%
	08:00	Index of Services 3M/3M	Feb	3M/3M	--	0.20%
US	14:30	Initial Jobless Claims	Apr11	1'000	--	--
	14:30	Continuing Claims	Apr4	1'000	--	--
Friday, 17.04.2026						
CA	14:15	Housing Starts	Mar	1'000	--	250.9k

Source: Bloomberg, J. Safra Sarasin as of 09.04.2026



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Market Performance

Global Markets in Local Currencies

Government Bonds	Current value	Δ 1W (bp)	Δ YTD (bp)	TR YTD in %
Swiss Eidgenosse 10 year (%)	0.42	1	10	-0.7
German Bund 10 year (%)	2.99	0	13	-0.4
UK Gilt 10 year (%)	4.75	-8	25	-0.7
US Treasury 10 year (%)	4.30	-5	17	0.3
French OAT - Bund, spread (bp)	63	-6	-8	
Italian BTP - Bund, spread (bp)	75	-11	5	

Stock Markets	Level	P/E ratio	1W TR in %	TR YTD in %
SMI - Switzerland	13'160	18.3	3.0	0.5
DAX - Germany	23'807	15.6	5.0	-2.8
MSCI Italy	1'510	12.9	3.4	4.6
IBEX - Spain	18'105	14.2	6.8	5.7
DJ Euro Stoxx 50 - Eurozone	5'896	15.9	6.0	2.4
MSCI UK	3'033	13.7	1.6	8.4
S&P 500 - USA	6'825	21.1	3.8	0.0
Nasdaq 100 - USA	25'082	23.4	4.4	-0.5
MSCI Emerging Markets	1'529	12.6	6.6	9.4

Forex - Crossrates	Level	3M implied volatility	1W in %	YTD in %
USD-CHF	0.79	7.6	-1.2	-0.2
EUR-CHF	0.92	5.0	0.2	-0.7
GBP-CHF	1.06	6.4	0.3	-0.5
EUR-USD	1.17	6.4	1.5	-0.5
GBP-USD	1.34	7.4	1.7	-0.4
USD-JPY	159.2	8.5	-0.3	1.8
EUR-GBP	0.87	4.6	-0.2	-0.1
EUR-SEK	10.87	6.9	-0.5	0.6
EUR-NOK	11.10	8.1	-1.4	-5.9

Commodities	Level	3M realised volatility	1W in %	YTD in %
Bloomberg Commodity Index	133	28.6	-2.0	18.3
Brent crude oil - USD / barrel	132	103.5	4.2	111.1
Gold bullion - USD / Troy ounce	4'765	32.2	0.1	9.8

Source: J. Safra Sarasin, Bloomberg as of 09.04.2026



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